2025 Empire Cup Premier Tournament
Information and Rules

1. Dates and Registration Fees

EMPIRE CUP PREMIER
Dates: June 20-22nd
Location: Dwight Merkle Sports Complex and Union Stadium
Age groups: U6-U19 (2019-2007)
Divisions: Platinum, Gold, and Silver (when bracketing is available)
3-Game Guarantee

COST:

- U6-U10 (2015-2019): $450 (Plus processing fees)
- U11/U12 (2013/2014): $950
- U13-19 (2006-2012): $1050

REFUND POLICY:

- Tournament cancellation prior to May 19th, 2024 - 90% refund
  Tournament cancellation after May 24th, 2024 - 75% refund
  Tournament cancellation after May 29th, 2024 - No Refund

- If the event or games are cancelled due to field playability, weather, or other extenuating circumstances, teams will be provided a refund proportional to the amount of games unable to be completed within the 3 game guarantee minus a $25 administrative fee and $25 GotSport software fee. If the only games required to be cancelled are the championship rounds and teams have completed 3 games, no refund will be issued. Cancellations decisions will be the authority of the tournament director and venue staff based on US Soccer Federation guidelines.

2. General Information

This tournament is open to all teams from US Club Soccer, Washington Youth Soccer, other USSF affiliated members and foreign countries.

Platinum, Gold, and Silver divisions will be offered at the Premier level. Divisions will be created according to number of teams registered in each bracket. Placement in division level will be determined by the tournament director and/or tournament scheduler. Every attempt to balance competition will be made with input from team representatives when possible.

Team registration must be completed via GotSport:
https://www.wesurfsc.com/empire-cup

Registration Fee must be paid at the time of registration. Registration closes at midnight on June 6th, 2025.

The tournament director, coordinator and committee or any representative of Empire Cup Tournament will not be liable for any expenses incurred by individual teams in the event the tournament is canceled in part or whole.

Empire Cup tournament director or assistant director reserves the right to terminate, suspend or forfeit any match for misconduct of coaches, players and spectators. The offending team will be removed from the facility and suspended from all remaining games.

Sale of any merchandise and on-site posting of non-Empire Cup related information/advertisement are strictly prohibited.

No pets are allowed at Plante's Ferry Sports Complex. Service animals must be cleared at the tournament headquarters.

Camper parking is available. More information to follow.

3. Team Check in Deadline

EMPIRE CUP PREMIER

If a team has not submitted rosters on TeamSnap Tournaments the team must check in at tournament headquarters at least 60' prior to their first scheduled game with a Club Registrar approved tournament roster or official roster. Club administration may submit a letter certifying that their recreational and Junior players not carded through their state association are insured through their club.

Teams must have approved rosters and a form of age verification available at each game if requested.

Players may be dual rostered to multiple teams with tournament director approval.

4. Roster Sizes

Teams may carry the following roster sizes;

Playing 4v4, no more than 8 players

Playing 5v5, no more than 10 players

Playing 7v7, no more than 14 players
Playing 9v9, no more than 16 players
Playing 11v11 age groups U13 to U14, no more than 18 players
Playing 11v11 age groups U15 and up, no more than 22 players
No roster changes will be permitted after a team roster has been approved at the tournament check-in.

5. Age Divisions

U6 – Players born in 2020
U7 – Players born in 2019
U8 – Players born in 2018
U9 – Players born in 2017
U10 – Players born in 2016
U11 – Players born in 2015
U12 – Players born in 2014
U13 – Players born in 2013
U14 – Players born in 2012
U15 – Players born in 2011
U16 – Players born in 2010
U17 – Players born in 2009
U19 – Players born in 2006/07/08

6. Illegal players

Any player that does not appear on the tournament roster shall be considered an illegal player.

Any team using an illegal player(s) shall forfeit each match the illegal player(s) were used.

7. Laws of the Game

All Games are to be played in accordance with FIFA & USSF Rules, except when specifically modified and communicated by the tournament director.

There will be a build out line for U9-U12.

No Heading will be allowed for U5-U12.

8. Protests

All protests and appeals may be filed with the Tournament Director or Assistant Tournament Director.

Any matter not resolved by the referee will be decided by the tournament director. The decision is deemed final.

9. Duration of the game

U6-8: two 25-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-9: two 25-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-10: two 25-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-11: two 25-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-12: two 25-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-13: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-14: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-15: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-16: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-17: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period
U-19: two 30-minute halves, 5-minute half time, no overtime period

All games will use a running clock. There will not be any stoppage of time. The tournament director may at his discretion adjust playing time.

The referee is the official timekeeper.

The games will start and end at the published times on the schedule.

Games may be shortened or cancelled due to weather. The tournament director has sole discretion to make the final decision.

In excessive heat additional water breaks will be provided by the referee at his discretion.

11. Scoring Method

Win	6 points
Tie	3 points
Loss	0 points
Shutout	1 point

Goals 1 point for each goal up to 3 maximum

Maximum of 10 points per game will be awarded per game.

After the preliminary rounds brackets for playoffs will be published. In the event of a tie within the same bracket the following rules will be used to determine the winner:

- Head to head competition
- Goal differential between all goals scored and all goals allowed during all tournament games. Team with the highest score differential will be declared the winner and move on to the playoffs.
- Least number of goals allowed in all tournament games combined
- If the above has been exhausted and a tie remains, the two teams will decide who advances with FIFA kicks from the penalty mark
- A coin toss may take the place of the shootout if agreed upon by both team coaches

Championship games
Championship games ending in a tie will go to two 5-minute Overtime period with 1 minute between two overtime periods. Overtime will be Golden Goal, if a goal is scored then the game ends. If a goal is not scored then it will go to FIFA Kicks from the penalty mark to determine the winner.

FIFA Kicks from the penalty mark
- Both teams will kick 5 times
- The kicks will alternate between teams
- If after both teams have taken 5 kicks the score remains equal additional kicks will be taken in same order until one team scores a goal more than the other team after the same number of kicks.
- Only players on the field at end of the game may participate in the kicks from the penalty mark.
- Each kick must be taken by a different player and all eligible players must take a kick before any player can take a second kick.

12. Score Reporting

Forfeited games will be reported as 1-0 in favor of the non-forfeited team. Empire Cup and all personnel are not responsible for expenses incurred for any team who did not play 3 matches due to forfeit.

The referee will report game scores at the end of each game. The referee will obtain initials of the team representative after the conclusion of the game.

A team representative must review and sign the game cards PRIOR to referee submitting the game day card at the end of the game.

In the case of discrepancy the game score reported prevails if both coaches and referee signed it.

13. Field and Game Equipment

Players must wear shin guards in accordance with FIFA laws.

No jewelry of any kind is allowed.

All teams must be checked in prior to the first game.

Jerseys must have visible numbers on the back of the uniforms and all numbers must be unique and must match the roster.

Casts and braces must be padded and approved by the referee prior to each match. Usage of case or brace in any intentional manner is grounds for removal from the tournament.

All teams must have alternate jerseys in case of color conflict. The team listed first on the schedule (home team) will wear white or light color jerseys. The visitor (away team) shall wear dark color jerseys. Home team is responsible for changing jerseys if there's color conflict.

Goalkeepers must be in jersey or vest of a different color than both team jersey color as well as referee shirt color.

Players and coaches will take the same side of the field. Spectators will take the opposite side from players and coaches. Team may have up to 4 officials with the players. All team officials must display an official coach card on a lanyard.

Designated home team must provide 3 game balls.

Field Size and Playing Format

- Field Size U6-U8 (2018-2020)= 4-vs-4; approx. 60ft x 75 ft
- Field Size U9/U10 (2016/2017)= 7-vs-7; approx 135 ft x 195 ft
- Field Size U11/U12 (2014/2015) = 9-vs-9; approx 160 ft x 225 ft
- Field Size U13 - U19 (2007-2013) = 11-vs-11; approx range 165 ft x 300 ft to 210 ft x 330 ft

14. Substitutions

Substitutions are unlimited in all age and divisions during the game.

Under no circumstances may substitutions take place after the game has ended in a tie and FIFA penalty kicks will be required to determine the winner

15. No Show and Forfeits

All tournament games must be played at the time and place as scheduled. Teams will be provided 5-minute grace period after the scheduled kick-off time before the match is considered a forfeit. The following number of players constitute a valid team:

- U8 and younger - 3 players minimum
- U9/U10 - 6 players minimum
- U11/U12 - 7 players minimum
- U13-U19 - 9 players minimum

Forfeited games shall be recorded as 1-0 (8 points) in favor of the team that did not forfeit.

A team that forfeits will not be declared a flight winner or a wild card team. If a flight winner forfeits a game, the team with the next best record shall be named the flight winner. In addition, the team that forfeits will not be declared a second place team in the flight. The team with the next best record in the flight will be declared the second place team and play in the semi-final game.

Any team forfeiting a championship game will not be entitled to individual trophies or team award.

Failure to check in prior to team's first scheduled game is grounds for a forfeit.

Playing a red carded player in the game following the receipt of a red card is grounds for a forfeit.

16. Inclement Weather

All tournament games must be played regardless of weather conditions. Only tournament director may cancel or postpone matches. Referees may only suspend a game.

If there's lightning in the area or if weather can cause risk to the participants and attendees of the games, play will be suspended. Players, coaches, referees and spectators must immediately move to vehicles or shelter upon suspension of the games, however, should not leave the area until games are declared complete.

Tournament director will have the authority to:

- Relocate or reschedule any games
- Change the duration of the games
- Cancel games
- If the weather stoppage is longer than 30 minutes, every effort will be made to complete the games. If first half of the game has been played then the Tournament Director has the sole discretion to call the game complete.
- If the game never started, every effort will be made to reschedule the game.

If the tournament director rules that during a preliminary round penalty kicks should be taken due to inclement weather or unplayable field conditions, the following rain rule will apply:

- Each team will take maximum of 5 penalty kicks
- At the end of 5 penalty kicks, the score will be recorded as 1-0 win for the team that has scored the most penalty kicks or 0-0 tie if both teams are tied in penalty kicks at the end of 5 kicks.
- In the overall standings, 6 points will be awarded for the win, 3 points for a tie and 0 points for a loss.
- There will be no refunds or reimbursement of tournament registration fees, hotels, car rentals or any other expenses incurred by the team for cancellation or forfeiture of the games.

17. Conduct

Players and coaches must be on one side of the field with spectators on the opposite side. Only those with valid player and staff card and listed on the approved tournament roster may be on the team's side of the field. Each team may have up to 4 registered officials.

Coaches have total responsibility of the conduct of their players, families and spectators at all times. Absolutely no derogatory remarks or gestures will be tolerated.

Players, coaches and spectators are expected to conduct themselves within the spirit of the Laws of the Game. Displays of temper or derogatory language are cause for ejection from the game and the surrounding field area. Repeated violation will result in suspension of the team from the tournament.

If a referee abandons the game due to misconduct of a team, that team shall forfeit the game.

If a referee abandons the game, the final score will remain as is at the time of abandonment.

Players, coaches, team officials and spectators ejected from the game by the referee may not attend the next scheduled game.

Players receiving 3 yellow card during the course of the tournament must sit out the next match

Any players receiving a red card ejection must sit out the next match.

A player receiving a second ejection will be prohibited from competing in additional tournament games.

Artificial noise makers are not permitted.

Smoking, vaping and chewing tobacco and alcoholic beverages are strictly prohibited on the tournament grounds.

Pets/Animals are not permitted on the tournament grounds.

Violation of the tournament rules may result in any of the following penalties:

- Ineligibility of a player or team from tournament play
- Forfeiture of a game(s)
- Removal from the tournament grounds

- Return of trophies or medals
- Revocation of titles

Refunds will not be provided if a team withdraws after registration deadline.

Refunds will not be provided if a team does not show up to the tournament.

The Tournament Director and/or Assistant Director have the final say in all matters.